The 12th Degree – Master Architect



The apron is white, lined and bordered with blue, and fringed with gold. On the flap is embroidered a protractor; and in the middle of the body a plain scale, a sector and the compasses, arranged to form a triangle. The colors are to remind us of the degrees of the Symbolic Lodge, the foundation of Masonry.

The cordon is a broad, blue watered ribbon, worn from the left shoulder to the right hip.

The jewel is a heptagonal medal of gold. On one side, in each angle is a five–pointed star, enclosed by a semicircle. In the center, on the same side, is an equilateral triangle, formed by arcs of circles. On the reverse side are five columns, representing the different orders of architecture, arranged from left to right, with the initial letter of the proper order below each, in old English letters —[T]uscan, [D]oric, [I]onic, [C]orinthian, [C]omposite. Above these columns are a sector and a slide–rule; below them, the three kinds of compasses, the plain

scale and parallel ruler. Between the second and third and the third and fourth columns are Phoenician letters equivalent to the English or Roman letters “R” and “B.” These letters have two meanings, one exoteric and the other esoteric. The exoteric meaning all may know; it is simply the initials of *Rab Benaim*, the Semitic name for the degree. You should pay particular attention to the symbolic meanings of the jewel and its designs in the ritual.

DUTY

Seek wisdom through knowledge.

LESSONS

Wisdom is a gift from God and should be preferred over riches.
Wisdom and knowledge bring honor, discretion and understanding.
Wisdom teaches the knowledge of God. Wisdom enables immortality.

FOR REFLECTION

Are you in control of your life?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Architect’s Tools.

In Masonic Degrees candidates makes a series of ceremonial prescribed circuits of the altar. This practice, called circumambulation, is derived from the ancients and existed among the Romans, Semites, Hindus, and others. It is thought to have been a rite of purification. The sun was believed to travel around the earth; the initiates imitated the movement of the sun when they made circuits around the altar. In the Symbolic Lodge, the circuits of the craftsmen at the installation of the officers symbolize the possession of the lodge by the new Master. In Scottish Rite Masonry, this ancient symbol of purification is adopted to represent a renewal in virtue through the performance of duty.

In addition to circumambulation, this degree is filled with numerous symbols which carry its teachings more than the actual ceremony. We are now advancing to the loftier philosophical lessons of Masonry and so encounter more complex symbolism.

CEREMONY

The crimson flames on the hangings represent the zeal and fervency required in the pursuit of wisdom from which a new man arises becoming renewed in virtue. This idea is symbolized in other degrees by the color green. The flames should also remind us that we have completed the earthly instruction of the Scottish Rite and will now advance from the realm of morality to that of true philosophy.

The lodge is lighted by three great lights, one each in the East, West and South. They are symbolic of the power, wisdom and beneficence of the Deity which were represented on the apron of the 5th Degree by three concentric circles. Behind the Master in the East are the columns representing the five orders of architecture. We are told these columns should remind us that Masonry, like architecture, is and has been the same in all countries and in all ages. They are also representative of the five divisions of Scottish Rite Masonry:

1. Tuscan– The Three Symbolic Lodge Degrees.
2. Doric– The Ineffable Degrees, 4th through 14th.
3. Ionic– The Second Temple Degrees, 15th and 16th.
4. Corinthian– The New Law Degrees, 17th and 18th.
5. Composite– The Chivalric and Philosophical Degrees, 19th through 32nd.

The night skies were important to the ancients, from whom many Masonic truths have been derived. Therefore, the North Star, Ursa Major (Big Dipper) and Venus, the Morning Star, are other important symbols incorporated in this degree. Ursa Major and the North Star appear in the North of the lodge and are representative of the Deity and faith. Venus is an emblem of the ever–approaching dawn of perfection and Masonic light.

It is here that we first encounter the Seal of Solomon—two interlaced triangles, one white and the other black—hinting at the principle of duality. In

the center of the 9 triangles, in old Samaritan characters, is one of the names of God, a substitute to the Hebrew for the true name of God which is ineffable.



To become a Master Architect, the candidate assumes the character of Adoniram who, according to Masonic tradition, was the first upon whom this degree was conferred. After the Master Hiram's death, five Intendants of the Building were appointed to assume the Master's duties. Adoniram, having gained superior knowledge and skill, was subsequently appointed Chief Architect of the Temple and the successor to the Master Hiram. The advancement of Adoniram to Master Architect teaches us that the ablest, wisest and best of every nation should be its leaders.

None of the degrees and their associated legends occurred in the time of Solomon. Masonry began early in the 17th century. The legends of the degrees are all symbolic and allegorical. We are urged to learn the allegorical meaning of this degree, in particular what the Master Hiram symbolizes. This explanation is not given in the ceremony; however, a hint is: what is meant by him is concealed by his name, Hiram. An explanation of various meanings is actually given in *Morals and Dogma* on page 81. In a political sense the character of Hiram symbolizes the executive head of a free government.

We are also reminded that Masons do not need any knowledge of geometry and mathematics as sciences to advance because the instruments of the architect and geometrician are also allegorical and symbolic. The different compasses represent that life and time are but a point in the center of eternity and the circle of God's attributes is infinite; this meaning may also be ascribed to the North Star and Ursa Major because they do not set in the northern hemisphere and, by the rotation of the earth, appear to draw circles in the night sky. The parallel ruler teaches us that we should be consistent and firm and possess a sense of equality

in mind and temper. The protractor represents a man who is upright, sincere, frank, moderate and punctual. The plain scale reminds us to live not only for ourselves, but for others and in just measure to serve ourselves, families, friends, neighbors and country. The sector teaches us to multiply our good deeds, divide what we can spare, and extract the good from the reverses and calamities of life. Finally, the slide rule prompts us to strive to grasp and solve the great problems in the universe and in our existence, to know and understand philosophy in the Masonic sense and to share our knowledge freely with others.

LECTURE

This lecture is concerned with the loftier heights of practical philosophy presented in the ceremony. Pike provides an excellent description in the opening paragraph of this lecture:

The great duties that are inculcated by the lessons taught by the working–instruments of a Grand Master Architect, demanding so much of us, and taking for granted the capacity to perform them faithfully and fully, bring us at once to reflect upon the dignity of human nature, and the vast powers and capacities of the human soul; and to that theme we invite your attention in this Degree. Let us begin to rise from earth toward the Stars (p. 189).

The entire lecture deals with the dignity of human nature and the vast powers of the human soul. Contemplation and knowledge, leads to the object of a Mason’s everlasting search: WISDOM. Though this wisdom is human wisdom, it nevertheless arises from the Deity and is a mirror of one of His attributes. Pike presents a convincing argument that each man can be and should be in control of his life. He conveys a beautiful and inspiring philosophy of life.

Knowledge and Wisdom (Human Nature):

There are greater and better things in us all, than the world takes account of, or than we take note of, if we would but find them out. And it is one part of our Masonic culture to find these traits of power and sublime devotion, to revive these faded impressions of generosity and self–sacrifice, the almost squandered

bequests of God's love and kindness to our souls; and to induce us to yield ourselves to their guidance and control (p. 192).

Never was a human being sunk so low that he had not, by God's gift, the power to rise. ...Every man has the power, and should use it, to make all situations, trials, and temptations instruments to promote his virtus and happiness; ... (pp. 192–193).

Life is what we make it, and the world is what we make it. The eyes of the cheerful and of the melancholy man are fixed upon the same creation; but very different are the aspects which it bears to them. To the one, creation; but very different are the aspects which it bears to them. To the one, it is all beauty and gladness;.... The other idly or mournfully gazes at the same scene, and everything wears a dull, dim, and sickly aspect. ...The eye makes that which it looks upon; the ear makes its own melodies and discords; the world without reflects the world within (p. 193).

Let the Mason never forget that life and the world are what we make them by our social character; by our adaptation, or want of adaptation to the social conditions, relationships, and pursuits of the world (p. 193).

In the long run, the mind will be happy, just in proportion to its fidelity and wisdom. When it is miserable, it has planted the thorns in its own path; it grasps them, and cries out in loud complaint; and that complaint is but the louder confession that the thorns which grew there, it planted (p. 195).

Faith in moral principles, in virtue, and in God, is as necessary for the guidance of a man, as instinct is for the guidance of an animal (p. 197).

The difference among men is not so much in their nature and intrinsic power, as in the faculty of communication. Some have the capacity of uttering and embodying in words their thoughts. All men, more or less, feel these thoughts. The glory of genius and the rapture of virtue, when rightly revealed, are diffused and shared among unnumbered minds (p. 200).

Knowledge and Wisdom (Human Soul):

Alone, the mind wrestles with the great problem of calamity, and seeks the solution from the Infinite Providence of Heaven, and thus is led directly to God (p. 189).

If we could cut off from any soul all the principles taught by Masonry, the faith in a God, in immortality, in virtue, in essential rectitude, that soul would sink into sin, misery, darkness, and ruin. If we could cut off all sense of these truths, the man would sink at once to the grade of the animal (p. 196).

Men do not feel the worth of their own souls. They are proud of their mental powers; but the intrinsic, inner, infinite worth of their own minds they do not perceive (p. 200).

Knowledge of the Deity:

Believe that there is a God; that He is our father; that He has a paternal interest in our welfare and improvement; that He has given us powers, by means of which we may escape from sin and ruin; that He has destined us to a future life of endless progress toward perfection and a knowledge of Himself—believe this, as every Mason should, and you can live calmly, endure patiently, labor resolutely, deny yourselves cheerfully, hope steadfastly and be conquerors in the great struggle of life (p. 195).

We must, of necessity, embrace the great truths taught by Masonry, and live by them, to live happily. "I put my trust in God," is the protest of Masonry against the belief in a cruel, angry, and revengeful God, to be feared and not reverenced by His creatures (p. 196).